

Yue Yao

Materiality, Medium, and Site in Transformation: Tracing *Shape of the Wind*

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In 2012, a large art installation was displayed inside St. Johannes-Evangelist Church in Berlin, Germany (fig. 1). The work, taking up the main space of the church hall, consisted of various abstract patterns in ink on unfolding paper. Beginning at the top of the dome, the installation hung to touch the floor, at which point it laid on the ground like a carpet. Similar to a traditional Chinese handscroll painting, however, a significant portion of the giant scroll remained rolled up as it approached the boundary of the church, leaving much of its contents unknown. The audience was able to view this work from the first and second floors of the church, thereby perceiving the work's various dimensions—its front, its back, and even its thickness. This work of art was created by the contemporary Chinese artist Bingyi (b. 1975) in April, 2012 in the Fuchun Mountains of China's Zhejiang Province. Given the name of the work, *Shape of the Wind: Fuchun Mountains*, it might seem odd that a representation of nature in China came to be displayed inside a church in Europe; as a work created on location in the Fuchun Mountains and then transferred to a final display space, one witnesses how the role of artist, both in presence and absence, complicates and reveals this transformation and leaves artistic traces on the work, as well as how the aspect of nature engages with the installation. The volume and gravity of the work had been naturally exposed through its method of display. The light in the church both projected upon the painting and penetrated its back, creating a unique visual effect on the surface of the painting. In this sense, how does its materiality as a paper-based scroll attempt to re-present the site where the work was created? Moreover, as the major pattern is presented in ink, how does this medium reflect the cultural and historical understanding of Chinese handscrolls and the specific place of the Fuchun mountains in general? With those

questions in mind, this paper will examine Bingyi's work from the perspective of transformation, which resists the work's unchanging and static nature while simultaneously turning its creators, materiality, and site-specificity into malleable entities.

### Transforming Materiality

In April, 2012, Bingyi traveled to the Fuchun Mountains in China's Zhejiang Province, a place where one of the most famous Chinese handscrolls, a *shan shui* painting (literally "mountain-water," often in reference to general landscape) called *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains* (fig. 2), was created. The creator of *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains* was a Yuan Dynasty scholar painter, Huang Gongwang (1269–1354), who resided in Fuchun, a site later famous for literati communities. Hundreds of years later, in 2012, Bingyi chose this place and envisioned her art work being created there. Similar to a traditional Chinese painting, Bingyi uses ink and Chinese rice paper as her medium; however, breaking with the practice of *shan shui* painting, Bingyi enlarged the scroll to land-art scale, using the mountain slope as the support base for the painting. At 160 meters long and 2.65 meters wide, the scroll was constructed out of individual sections of rice paper that would take on the curve and shape of the mountain slope.

After placing the sections, Bingyi burned paper in a bucket (fig. 3) and employed the flow of the wind to spread the ash onto the painting's surface. She then traced the structure of the ashes, which pulled the ink onto it, creating the unique shapes on the painting's surface. By dropping, spilling, and splashing ink, Bingyi both adhered to the pattern of the ashes and expressively created her work. With her were two assistants, one of whom would lead the way by

tossing the ash, with the other spraying water onto the splashed ink in order to facilitate the ink forming into its various patterns.

As the burning paper turned into ash and the wet ash fused with the ink to become one with the medium, the materiality of the work was in a state of constant transformation. Indeed, burning has long been a ritual practice in traditional China for people to commemorate the deceased that is continued to this day. The anthropologist Fred Blake argues that burning paper can be seen as a liminary phase of the liturgy that symbolizes the renewed order of things in mundane space-time.<sup>1</sup> When paper is burned, once-visible information becomes invisible and ethereal. Bingyi claims that “When the collector died, he wanted to take the painting with him. For him, the painting became complete only in fire. Paper is only real when it burns.”<sup>2</sup> The burning paper thus becomes a mediator between the living and the dead, between the material and the spirit. By splashing the ashes onto the paper, Bingyi draws people’s attention to a critical component of the work: the immaterialized and invisible change occurring within it.

At the same time, this metaphor emphasizes the unseen force that built the work, thereby juxtaposing it with the seen force of the artist’s hand. Bingyi argues that “the ink itself will shape into many thousands of different forms (fig. 4),” ultimately becoming the “natural topography” that is the creator of the ink installation.<sup>3</sup> The slope of the mountain also provides a canvas for

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<sup>1</sup> Fred Blake, *Burning Money: The Material Spirit of the Chinese Lifeworld* (Honolulu: University of Hawaii Press, 2011), 85.

<sup>2</sup> Her accompany, Rick Widmer, has recorded the thought and the process of art making of *Shape of the Wind* in a documentary film, “Bingyi: Fuchun, 2012. 05,” Youtube, July, 3, 2012, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A5ZXRfioUzc>.

<sup>3</sup> Ibidem.

gravity as the ink is gradually propelled downward and further shaped by poured water into natural patterns. The contingency<sup>4</sup> of the work, made commensurate to that of gravity, wind, and water, thrusts the material into a state of transformation. Despite this parallel, however, a consistency between the word of the artist and her own practice remains. In *Shape of the Wind*, although Bingyi indeed allows for such changes of the material, she is also ultimately the one who directs the pouring of the ink and decides when the work should be done and when enough is “enough,” the word she uses to her assistants to signal when they should stop pouring water onto the paper. In this way, the artist stills retains control of processing the work of art, further evidenced in a screenshot of the documentary film (fig. 5) that shows that Bingyi did not always follow the exact pattern of the ashes. Rather, she took a more expressive and autonomous attitude when pouring the ink onto the paper. Instead of appropriating the gesture of the artist, Bingyi walks on this giant paper with bare feet and operates her body as a mediator of her painting. The final result of the painting, thus, was more than a “natural topography” and rather a representation of the site and the foot-prints of the artist and her assistants.

### Transforming Medium, Mobility

The ink patterns in the work along with the gestures Bingyi used when creating it compel the audience to understand the work as an action painting.<sup>5</sup> Due to a similar physical engagement

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<sup>4</sup> The contingency features an openness to materials, as described in Reza Negarestani, “Contingency and Complexity,” in *The Medium of Contingency*, ed. Robin Mackay (London: Falmouth Urbanomic, 2015), 11–16.

<sup>5</sup> The description of its documentary film, Widmer, “Bingyi: Fuchun, 2012. 05.”

with her materials in regard to gravity and improvisation of the artistic process, one might associate her work with that of the American abstract expressionist painter Jackson Pollock. The art critic Harold Rosenberg claims in his article “The American Action Painters” that “since the painter has become an actor, the spectator has to think in a vocabulary of action: its inception, duration, direction—psychic state, concentration, and relaxation of the will, passivity, alert waiting.”<sup>6</sup> Essentially, for most “action painters,” spontaneity is being brought into the art process; however, for Bingyi’s *Shape of the Wind*, the quintessential blank surface upon which the creator creates is augmented by a unique surface, the scroll, which brings to the final work a sense of mobility, both from its viewing experience and the affordance of its medium.

Though *Shape of the Wind* is differently experienced when compared to an actual handscroll, the impact of that experience to the reference medium is artfully retained in the work. Typically, a traditional Chinese handscroll is revealed by spreading the scroll out; then after viewing the art or writing inside from right to left, the two ends are rolled back together again, a process which art historian Wu Hung points out embodies the reverse gaze of a handscroll painting (fig. 6).<sup>7</sup> In a traditional handscroll, the painting plane is eventually reversed as the viewer rolls the scroll back together so that the next viewer can begin the whole process anew. During this final act, wherein the viewer now gazes from the end to the beginning, there is a review of the entire process, and thus, in a way, an opportunity to rethink the totality of the work

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<sup>6</sup> Harold Rosenberg, “The American Action Painters,” *ARTnews* (January 1952): 23.

<sup>7</sup> For further information on the medium of handscroll or other types of Chinese painting, see Wu Hung, *The Double Screen: Medium and Representation in Chinese Painting* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1996) and Jerome Silbergeld, *Chinese Painting Style: Media, Methods, and Principles of Form* (Seattle: University of Washington Press, 1982), 12–15.

itself. This "reversal" is metaphorically represented in *Shape of the Wind* as the viewer travels back and forth alongside the scroll, similar to the way one travels in the mountains and feels nature. While a handscroll painting indicates the use of "hands" to view the work of art contained within, the monumental size of this installation required that it be viewed by "foot" as its audience wandered the church. Another aspect "reversed" by the installation is the notion of a handscroll's mobility; while the actual item can be easily carried to different places and shared with others, thereby creating a network that links its location of creation and the myriad places it can be viewed and commented upon, *Shape of the Wind* must be deliberately transported. In both cases, the contrast between an actual handscroll and Bingyi's representation of one emphasizes how the artist's role is not only engaged within the creation of the work, but also during its afterlife as it is transported and displayed.

#### Transforming Site, Literati Painter

Due to the medium, *Shape of the Wind* affords a sense of mobility itself—the work is both able to be displayed inside a church in Europe while simultaneously exhibiting traces of the natural site of creation. At any rate, the specific site in which Bingyi choose to create her project must be considered, which requires one to wonder: how does *Shape of the Wind*'s choice of place expand the concept and understanding of "site" in art practice?

The Fuchun Mountains, the site of the project's beginnings, can be traced back in art history to the Yuan Dynasty and Huang Gongwang's *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains*. A monochromatic landscape painting, *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains* shows a comprehensive

view of the Fuchun Mountains where Huang had lived. As a scholar-painter, Huang's style of using ink to paint became a symbol of scholarly self-cultivation and erudition. This approach would eventually grow into a popular means of social interaction and establish a literati community in that era.<sup>8</sup> In essence, *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains* represents how an artist's personal biography and identity are inherently intertwined with the work of art itself and affect its final form. Thus, the fact that Bingyi chose this site in particular and employed ink as her painting medium should be seen a reference to art as a practice of self-expression. Furthermore, as Bingyi doesn't live in this area, her engaging with the Fuchun Mountains is also a reference to an influential scholar-painter in ancient China and places her work in juxtaposition with those great literati landscape paintings of the past.

When one thinks of site-specificity, one often associates the concept with the words of Richard Serra, "to remove the work is to destroy the work,"<sup>9</sup> a destruction which *Shape of the Wind* does not possess due to its mobility. However, if one thinks of site as something more than a place, but rather a conceptual term, one might get a new understanding of its function in *Shape of the Wind*. Art historian Miwon Kwon suggests three paradigms of site specificity—phenomenological, social/institutional, and discursive.<sup>10</sup> The idea of "site" therefore could be

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<sup>8</sup> For more information on Yuan literati painting as a cultural identity of the literati community, see Yu Christina Yu, "Building a Community through Painting: Fourteenth Century Chinese Scholars" (PhD diss., University of Chicago, 2011), 89–142.

<sup>9</sup> Richard Serra, *The Destruction of Titled Arc: Documents*, ed. Clara Weyergraf-Serra and Martha Buskirk (Cambridge: MIT Press, 1991), 38.

<sup>10</sup> Miwon Kwon, *One Place After another: Site-Specific Art and Locational Identity* (Cambridge: MIT Press, 2002), 30.

expanded and transformed while identifying the public role of the artist and of the artwork. Even though there are limited onlookers participating in the process of the work, due to Bingyi creating the project in seclusion in the mountains rather than in a public social place, *Shape of the Wind* still implies the meaning of site through Bingyi's process of tracing the original site of the work from a historical and cultural perspective. In this way, Bingyi also implicitly addresses her identity not just as an artist, but a literati—someone who thinks rather than merely paints, who is willing to bring a specific cultural expression in China into a spiritual space for Europeans, a church. In this way, Bingyi, with her identity as a public scholar and a contemporary literati artist, promotes a hybridity of cultural exchange into the practice of art.<sup>11</sup>

When the work was displayed in the church of Berlin, and when the viewer approached the final exhibit, even though the artist was in absence, one could follow the traces of Bingyi's personal footprint at Fuchun, as only the artist and her assistants who were present at the place of creation could. As such, the notion of site-specificity of the work was thereby shifted and changed. Through re-presenting the site and the unique approach towards the medium in *Shape of the Wind*, the audience enters a new field of cultural exchange created by Bingyi and becomes part of the contemporary literati and artistic community as well.

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<sup>11</sup> Bingyi took advanced degrees in art history and archeology at Yale University and became an art history professor at the University of Buffalo. The art writer, Johnathan Goodman, uses the postmodern literati artist to describe Bingyi, in Johnathan Goodman, "Bingyi: The artist at work," Bingyi, accessed December 8, 2020, <http://www.bingyi.info/essays/bingyi-artist-work/>.



Fig 1. Bingyi, *Shape of the Wind*. 2012, installation, St. Johannes-Evangelist-Kirche, Berlin  
Image: “Bingyi: Fuchun, 2012.05,” Youtube, accessed March 19, 2021, <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=A5ZXRfioUzc>.



Fig 2. Huang Gongwang, *Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains* (in portion), 1350. Image: “Dwelling in the Fuchun Mountains,” Wikipedia, accessed March 19, 2021, [https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dwelling\\_in\\_the\\_Fuchun\\_Mountains](https://en.m.wikipedia.org/wiki/Dwelling_in_the_Fuchun_Mountains).



Fig. 3. Bingyi Burning Paper. Image: “Bingyi: Fuchun, 2012.05.”

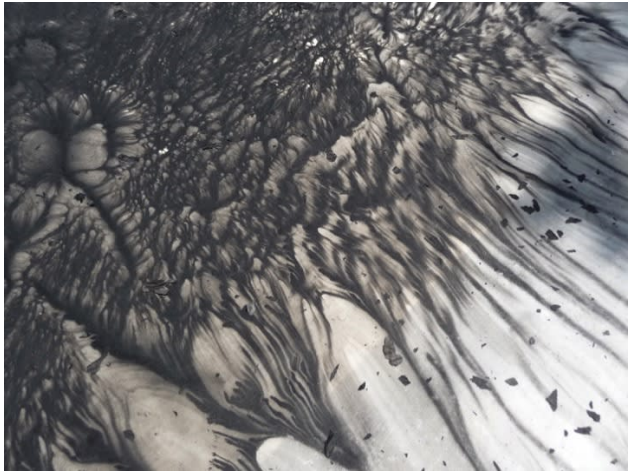


Fig. 4 Details of *Shape of the Wind*. Image: “Shape of the wind,” Bingyi, accessed March 19, 2021, <http://www.bingyi.info/2012-2/shape-of-the-wind/>.



Fig. 5. The artist at work. Image: “Bingyi: Fuchun, 2012.05.”



Fig. 6 How one views a typical Chinese handscroll painting. Image: Wu Hung, *The Double Screen*, 58.

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